

Course report SF2222 Citizens, Politicians and the Media

Spring semester 2024

The course is a joint venture between the Department of Political Science and the Department of Journalism, Media and Communication. It is an elective course in the Master's Programme in Political Science and the Master's Programme in Political Communication. It is given in the first module of the second semester, and awards 15 credits/hp upon completion.

The aim of the course is to give students the conceptual and theoretical tools to analyze how “the will of the people” – as a major goal of democracies – can be or is achieved. The course draws on and teaches the latest research on voting behaviour, political psychology, political participation, political representation, political communication, journalism, and media.

The course is thematically structured around four segments: the first is about more normative considerations and theories of democracy, political and media systems; the second investigates the role of citizens, drawing on individual-level research on public opinion, political participation, and voting behaviour; the third covers politicians as representatives, including prominent theories of representation; and the fourth covers research on media and communication with relevance for democracy .

The course is organizationally structured into two different parts: the first consists of input from lecturers through 14 different lectures, concluded with a written exam; and the second consists of a mix of peer-to-peer learning and individual meetings with lecturers to write a literature review that is presented and discussed at the very end of the course.

The course has been running for several years already, albeit with changing lecturers. Unlike other courses in the master's programme, the course is fairly lecture intensive, and includes lectures given by researchers from another but related field to political science. Passing the course requires passing the written exam, the literature review, as well as peer-to-peer workshops, supervision meetings and an Academic Honesty test.

Completion rate

Out of the 33 students that were registered on the course 18 (54 percent) have fully completed the course (as of Sept.2024). Of these, in turn, 10 (56 percent) received the grade VG. The completion rate is lower than previous year (62 percent). However, looking at the two major exam tasks the picture is better. In 2024 27 students have completed the research review, and 23 have at least G for the written exam. Instead, the other – minor – examination tasks in the course seem to be an obstacle for some students. In particular, the newly introduced Academic Honesty test has still not been taken by 9 students.

Assessment survey

Below are the results from the evaluation survey filled in by students (n= 10, corresponding to 30 percent of the 33 students registered on the course). The response rate is low, in relation to the previous semester, and this should be kept in mind when interpreting results.

Assessments, average between 1 (very bad) to 5 (very good)	<i>Score 2022</i>	<i>Score 2023</i>	<i>Score 2024</i>
Overall assessment of the course	3.8	4.5	4.0
... of lectures	3.9	4.2	4.5
... of teachers	4.2	4.7	4.4
... of the literature	3.8	4.1	3.8
... of the written exam	3.3	3.8	2.7
... of the first writing workshop (peer-to-peer)	2.6	4.0	4.3
... of the second writing workshop (peer-to-peer)	2.7	4.0	3.7
... of the personal supervision?	3.8	4.1	4.2
... of the final seminar	4.2	4.3	4.5
... of the course's organization	3.6	4.4	4.4
... of the workload (5=not at all demanding; 1= much too demanding)	2.3	2.5	2.9

The results are overall similar to previous year (2023) and considerably better than in 2022.

Positives

The lectures, as well as the research review work with supervision and final seminar, have received better evaluations than previous years. The format introduced in 2023 with peer-to-peer workshops where a teacher is also present seems to have worked well this semester too. Several of the comments specifically praise the lecturers and the organization and structure of the course also gets very good reviews.

Negatives

In particular the written examination was given a more negative evaluation than in previous two semesters. Some remarks concerned the amount of text to read in a short period of time, and a feeling that a lot has to be “memorized”, and that only asking four exam questions will not cover the course properly.

It should however be noted that the number of texts included in the literature list has been reduced somewhat in recent years.

Some students also noted that the timing of the workshops has not always been ideal.

Course coordinator's general evaluation and suggestions for the future

All in all the course has run smoothly. The course content is deemed both interesting and intellectually stimulating by the students. Generally, the course structure is adequate and the workload of the course seem to be reasonable, although the format and the workload of the written exam has been questioned by some students.

Only smaller changes may be considered for 2025.

- See to that the workshops/peer sessions and supervisor meetings are better distributed timewise (as some students remarked there was too little time between these meetings).
- Possibly increasing the number of questions in the written exam (a format with 7-8 questions has been used in previous years).
- It may be wise to better introduce the Academic honesty test and let students take the test in class.

1. October, 2024

Nicklas Håkansson, course coordinator